

The art of the classical world took the form of statuary, painted pottery, wall paintings and mosaics, and architecture. In general, Roman art took the ideas of both the Greeks and the Etruscans (a people who dominated northern Italy by the 6th century BCE; see p.106) and developed it in new ways. While the Greeks loved idealized beauty, symmetry, and perfect proportion, the Romans showed a practical genius—clear in engineering feats such as the Colosseum (see pp.110–111). The Romans were influenced by Greek art through trading contacts and the changing fortunes of the Greek and Roman Empires: while the Greeks dominated parts of Italy in the Archaic era (see BEFORE), by 146 BCE, the

renders fabric with great realism. Polyclitus' *Doryphorus* (Spear Bearer) reveals a more realistic pose and musculature—informed by the Greeks' study of the human body, aided by observing naked athletes. It also displays a mathematically calculated ideal of beauty with perfectly proportioned limbs and body.

Realism

Classical styles continued into the Hellenistic period, but, while sculptures such as the famous Venus de Milo retain an ideal of female beauty, works



Classical black figure vase
Greek vases often had dark figures against a red clay background, as in this example, or red figures on black. The painters were highly skilled and the style evolved over time.

has been lost (except for vase painting), but many surviving Roman wall paintings give an idea of the lost art. Those from Pompeii (see p.112) and Herculaneum illustrate a particular talent for creating three-dimensional illusions of scenes such as mythological dramas on a flat surface, and for expertly rendering shading, highlights, and perspective.

Classical Art

The art of ancient Greece and Rome—often known collectively as Classical Art—brought into being a wide range of different styles and approaches. These have had an enormous impact on Western art for many centuries, right up to the present day.

Romans controlled all of Greece. Generally speaking, art became more realistic over time, moving from the idealized form of the early period to the realism of the later Hellenistic period (c. 323–146 BCE).

Classical Greece

The Classical era of Greek history (c. 480–323 BCE) saw the flowering of “high Classical” art in an imperial Athens (see pp.100–01). The magnificent Parthenon temple (see pp.94–95) was built on the city’s acropolis, adorned with sculptures created under the supervision of the sculptor Phidias.

During the Classical period, sculpture began to show greater realism than the idealized style of earlier periods. Myron’s *Discobolus* (Discus Thrower) is a masterly attempt to freeze realistic movement, and the unattributed Apollo Belvedere statue

were appearing filled with great emotion, dynamism, and expression—such as the Samothrace Nike (or Winged Victory), the Laocoön group (see left), and the Dying Gaul (see p.134).

Idealization and beauty now started to seem less important. Images appeared depicting characters from everyday life, such as a woman at a market or a boy strangling a goose.

Workshops in the ancient world at this time produced statues of all styles, in clay, marble, and bronze. These sold all over the world, to a rising number of private patrons. Before the Hellenistic era there had been little sense of “art” as a separate creative entity—statues were made to mark a grave, glorify a temple, or commemorate a war; vases often had practical uses. However, wealthy buyers who had seen statues of famous figures now wanted a portrait of themselves, or figures to decorate their villas. Seeing different styles gave rise to the first sense of a “history of art.”

The art of Rome

Many of the Greek statues that survive today are actually Roman copies. In many ways the Romans simply copied the art of the Greeks, although they later went on to create their own artistic identity. Ancient Greek painting

The art of floor mosaics, using tiny pieces of colored stone (*tesserae*), was invented by the Greeks, but is the Romans who are famous for their mosaic work. Imperial Rome saw mosaic pavements and walls featuring ambitious schemes and imagery.

The Romans created monumental architecture and statues that celebrated the glories and wealth of their rule—

“Beauty consists in the proportions...”

GALEN, GREEK PHYSICIAN, 129–C. 200 CE

Trajan’s column and the Arch of Constantine, for example. Trajan’s column was designed by a Greek architect, Apollodorus of

Damascus, showing a continuing connection between Greek and Roman art. The Romans also used the Greek temple form, often placing it on a platform to make it more impressive and filling its panels with sculptures plundered from Greece. Their grand villas overflowed with statues, while Roman leaders used the power of art as propaganda. Without the Roman use of Greek art, much of its style and influence might have been lost to us.

ZEUXIS (5th century BCE) was one of ancient Greece’s most famous painters. Ancient writers told a famous tale about Zeuxis painting an image of grapes that was so realistic that birds tried to peck it. Sadly, none of his work survives today.

The art of ancient Greece and Rome has influenced many later cultures.

BYZANTINE ART

Domed buildings, perfected by the Romans, became a distinctive feature of the eastern Byzantine empire. The 6th-century CE church of Hagia Sophia, in the former Byzantine capital, Constantinople, is one example.



HAGIA SOPHIA, ISTANBUL

THE RENAISSANCE AND BEYOND

15th-century Europe rediscovered the art and architecture of Classical Greece and Rome **250–51** >>. Sculptors and painters, such as Raphael in Italy, gained a classical understanding of human anatomy, and architects created buildings informed by ancient Greek temples.



16TH-CENTURY PAINTING BY RAPHAEL

Corinthian column

The Greeks created several different “orders” (styles) of columns for their buildings, which the Romans later adapted. This column is in the Greek Corinthian style, which was especially popular in Rome.

